

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 811

By Camper

A RESOLUTION to commemorate the 100th anniversary of Black History Month.

WHEREAS, February 2026 marks the 100th anniversary of Black History Month, an observance that honors the achievements, resilience, and enduring contributions of African Americans to our national story; and

WHEREAS, Black History Month traces its origins to 1926, when the renowned historian Dr. Carter G. Woodson and the Association for the Study of Negro Life and History established Negro History Week; and

WHEREAS, what began as a weeklong celebration grew steadily in recognition and importance, expanding in 1976 during the nation's Bicentennial into a monthlong observance that continues to inspire Americans; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee has a long and distinguished tradition of observing Black History Month and honoring the achievements of African Americans whose courage, leadership, and cultural contributions have profoundly influenced the history and character of this State; and

WHEREAS, the Volunteer State proudly claims among its native daughters and sons many whose lives and legacies illuminate the broader struggle for justice and equality, including the fearless journalist and anti-lynching crusader Ida B. Wells-Barnett; the trailblazing surgeon, educator, and legislator Dr. Dorothy Lavinia Brown; and the Honorable Lois M. DeBerry, former Speaker Pro Tempore of the Tennessee House of Representatives, whose leadership and integrity inspired all who served with her; and

WHEREAS, in 2019, Leader Karen D. Camper achieved a historic milestone as the first African American and first Black woman to lead a major political party caucus in the Tennessee General Assembly, embodying the progress envisioned by those who came before her; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee's Historically Black Colleges and Universities, including Tennessee State University, Fisk University, Meharry Medical College, Lane College, LeMoyne-Owen College, and Knoxville College, have served as beacons of excellence and opportunity, educating generations of leaders, scholars, and citizens; and

WHEREAS, the rich legacy of Knoxville's Black history endures through the work of Knoxville College and the Beck Cultural Exchange Center, which stand as cornerstones of education and preservation of African-American heritage and education in East Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, the Highlander Folk School (now the Highlander Research and Education Center) in New Market played a pivotal role as a training ground for Civil Rights leaders, including Rosa Parks, John Lewis, Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., and Septima Clark; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee native Alex Haley of Henning profoundly shaped the nation's understanding of African-American history and ancestry through his landmark works *Roots: The Saga of an American Family* and *The Autobiography of Malcolm X*; and

WHEREAS, as the nation marks the 100th anniversary of Black History Month, it is fitting that we affirm Tennessee's ongoing commitment to teaching accurate and inclusive history and promoting civic understanding, as we encourage communities across the State to commemorate the centennial of Black History Month through educational and cultural programming; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we commemorate the 100th anniversary of Black History Month in February 2026 and honor the remarkable legacy of African-American achievement, perseverance, and leadership that continues to shape our State and our nation.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we encourage communities, schools, and cultural institutions across Tennessee to commemorate Black History Month's centennial year through educational and cultural programming.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that appropriate copies of this resolution be transmitted to the National Civil Rights Museum in Memphis, the Beck Cultural Exchange Center in Knoxville, the Highlander Research and Education Center in New Market, the Alex Haley Museum and Interpretive Center in Henning, and the Association for the Study of African American Life and History in Washington, D.C., with this final clause omitted from such copies and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.